Venezuela’s New Leader Is Trying to Run Out the Clock on Trump

委内瑞拉新领导人试图拖延特朗普的任期

in Bogotá, Colombia, and

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After the raid that captured Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro, the Trump administration called on his vice president, Delcy Rodríguez, to release hundreds of political prisoners—a test of her willingness to break with Maduro’s repression.

Nearly a month later, 303 political prisoners have been freed, according to a Venezuelan human-rights organization, while more than 700 remain behind bars. Rodriguez on Friday pledged a general amnesty for political prisoners—without making it clear who would be released or when.

Her handling of U.S. pressure over political prisoners reflects Rodriguez’s broader strategy, said current and former U.S. officials and the Venezuelan opposition. She aims to outlast Trump’s focus on her country by giving ground on demands that benefit her, such as allowing foreign investment in oil and other areas, while slow-walking political concessions that would lead to real change.

The ultimate goal is to preserve her position, the officials and opposition figures said, at the top of a system that Maduro, with her help on international trade and economics, created over the past 12 years.

“The best strategy for Delcy is just to wait the U.S. out,” said Ricardo Hausmann, a former minister of planning in Venezuela and professor at the Harvard Kennedy School.

As the 2026 midterms approach, U.S. involvement in Venezuela could become a political liability for Trump, giving Rodriguez and her allies an incentive to run out the clock, people involved in U.S. discussions about Venezuela said. A majority of American voters reject deeper U.S. involvement in Venezuela, according to a recent Wall Street Journal poll, and disapprove of Trump’s engagement abroad instead of focusing on the economy.

In calls with Secretary of State Marco Rubio, with whom she has been speaking three times a week, Rodriguez has offered to cooperate on the Trump administration’s plans, particularly opening Venezuela’s oil sector to American companies, U.S. officials say.

The 56-year-old interim leader appears to be betting that time is on her side, offering the U.S. president the kind of economic deals and concessions he prizes to convince him that a managed status quo is better than a destabilizing, uncertain transition.

So far, the strategy seems to be paying off.

在哥伦比亚波哥大，以及

2026年1月31日上午8:00（美国东部时间）

在抓捕委内瑞拉总统尼古拉斯·马杜罗的突袭行动之后，特朗普政府呼吁其副总统德尔西·罗德里格斯释放数百名政治犯——以此考验她是否愿意打破马杜罗的镇压政策。

近一个月后，据一个委内瑞拉人权组织称，已有303名政治犯获释，而仍有700多人身陷囹圄。罗德里格斯周五承诺对政治犯实行大赦——但没有明确说明谁将获释以及何时获释。

现任和前任美国官员以及委内瑞拉反对派表示，她处理美国在政治犯问题上的压力，反映了罗德里格斯更广泛的策略。她旨在通过在有利于自己的要求上让步，例如允许外国投资石油和其他领域，同时缓慢推进可能带来真正改变的政治让步，来拖延特朗普对她国家的关注。

官员和反对派人士表示，最终目标是保住她在马杜罗在过去12年里，在她协助国际贸易和经济的情况下建立的这个体系中的最高地位。

“对德尔西来说，最好的策略就是拖延美国，”委内瑞拉前计划部长、哈佛肯尼迪学院教授里卡多·豪斯曼说。

参与美国与委内瑞拉讨论的人士表示，随着2026年中期选举临近，美国介入委内瑞拉可能成为特朗普的政治负担，这给了罗德里格斯及其盟友拖延时间的动机。根据《华尔街日报》最近的一项民意调查，大多数美国选民反对美国更深入地介入委内瑞拉，并对特朗普将精力放在国外而非国内经济表示不满。

美国官员表示，在与国务卿马可·卢比奥（她每周与他通话三次）的通话中，罗德里格斯表示愿意配合特朗普政府的计划，特别是向美国公司开放委内瑞拉的石油部门。

这位56岁的临时领导人似乎在赌时间站在她这一边，向美国总统提供他所珍视的经济协议和让步，以说服他受控的现状优于破坏稳定、不确定的过渡。

到目前为止，这一策略似乎正在奏效。

Trump has repeatedly praised Rodriguez as a “terrific person” who is making “tremendous progress.” He has said Rodriguez will eventually visit the White House and floated a visit to Venezuela himself. “We have a very good relationship with the leaders of Venezuela, and we’re going to keep it that way,” Trump said Tuesday.

特朗普多次称赞罗德里格斯是“了不起的人”，正在取得“巨大进展”。他说罗德里格斯最终将访问白宫，并暗示他本人也将访问委内瑞拉。特朗普周二表示：“我们与委内瑞拉领导人关系非常好，我们将保持这种关系。”

Rodriguez has cast herself as the architect of a new order while keeping tight control over how changes are carried out. In her call this week for a general amnesty, she said it would cover what she called “the entire period of extremist violence from 1999 to the present.” That includes Maduro’s term and that of his predecessor, the late Hugo Chávez, who turned Venezuela into a socialist economy that collapsed with a decline in oil prices a decade ago. Over that time, Venezuela has been roiled by civic unrest, the exodus of eight million citizens and an attempted coup in 2002.

罗德里格斯将自己塑造成新秩序的缔造者，同时严格控制变革的实施方式。她本周呼吁实行大赦时表示，这将涵盖她所称的“从1999年至今的整个极端主义暴力时期”。这包括马杜罗及其前任、已故的乌戈·查韦斯的任期，查韦斯将委内瑞拉变成了一个社会主义经济体，该经济体在十年前油价下跌后崩溃。在此期间，委内瑞拉一直受到公民动荡、八百万公民外流以及2002年未遂政变的困扰。

She also announced the closure of the Helicoide, a Caracas detention center known for its brutal conditions for political prisoners.

她还宣布关闭加拉加斯的赫利科伊德拘留中心，该中心以其对政治犯的残酷条件而闻名。

In practice, who gets released—and when—will depend on the final text of the law. Rodriguez said those convicted of “serious human-rights abuses” wouldn’t get amnesty. She didn’t define those crimes.

实际上，谁能获释以及何时获释，将取决于法律的最终文本。罗德里格斯表示，被判犯有“严重侵犯人权罪”的人将不会获得大赦。她没有定义这些罪行。

Rubio has outlined a three-phase plan that focuses first on stabilization, then recovery and finally a political transition. But Trump has made it clear that he isn’t giving priority to a timetable for free elections, people involved in the discussions said.

卢比奥概述了一个三阶段计划，首先侧重于稳定，然后是复苏，最后是政治过渡。但参与讨论的人士表示，特朗普已明确表示他不会优先考虑自由选举的时间表。

A White House official said that the U.S. now has control and leverage over Venezuela’s interim authorities and that the Venezuelan people would be responsible for making transformational changes to their country.

一位白宫官员表示，美国现在对委内瑞拉临时当局拥有控制权和影响力，委内瑞拉人民将负责对其国家进行变革。

The U.S. has dispatched a team of diplomats to potentially reopen the embassy in Caracas. Trump ordered U.S. officials to reopen commercial airspace over Venezuela, clearing the way for American carriers to resume service to and from the country for the first time since 2019.

美国已派遣一个外交官团队，可能重新开放驻加拉加斯大使馆。特朗普命令美国官员重新开放委内瑞拉领空，为美国航空公司自2019年以来首次恢复往返该国的服务扫清了道路。

A few hours later, the National Assembly approved a new hydrocarbons law to ease the path for foreign investment in oil—ending a quarter-century of state-imposed barriers to entry for most international energy companies.

几小时后，国民议会批准了一项新的碳氢化合物法，以便利外国石油投资——结束了长达四分之一世纪的国家对大多数国际能源公司设置的进入壁垒。

For Venezuela’s opposition, the fear is that the arrangement with Rodriguez could harden into a long-term status quo.

对委内瑞拉反对派来说，他们担心与罗德里格斯的安排可能会固化为长期的现状。

“We are just acknowledging reality, and that is we have to work with the people who are in charge of the government,” Rubio told lawmakers on Thursday.

“我们只是承认现实，那就是我们必须与掌管政府的人合作，”卢比奥周四对议员们说。

Rubio, a Cuban-American who had long called for Maduro’s ouster, is perceived as the architect of Trump’s strategy in Venezuela and in Latin America generally. Though he insisted the end goal is a democratic Venezuela that “looks nothing like this,” Rubio declined to say if U.S. officials have a plan to make it happen.

卢比奥是一位古巴裔美国人，长期以来一直呼吁推翻马杜罗，他被认为是特朗普在委内瑞拉乃至整个拉丁美洲战略的制定者。尽管他坚称最终目标是一个“完全不同于现在”的民主委内瑞拉，但卢比奥拒绝说明美国官员是否有计划实现这一目标。

“It can’t take forever,” he said when asked whether Rodriguez remaining in power in six months would be a failure. “If progress isn’t being made, we’ll have very different feelings about it.”

当被问及罗德里格斯在六个月后仍掌权是否会是失败时，他说：“这不能永远拖下去。如果进展不顺利，我们对此会有非常不同的看法。”

In Trump's first term, Rodriguez was sanctioned for her role in helping Maduro "maintain power and solidify his authoritarian rule." She was also designated for a travel ban in the European Union, which froze her assets. Those sanctions remain in place.

在特朗普的第一任期内，罗德里格斯因帮助马杜罗"维持权力并巩固其独裁统治"而受到制裁。她还被欧盟列入旅行禁令，并冻结了她的资产。这些制裁措施仍然有效。

If Trump gets what he wants on economic policy in Venezuela, the president could be reluctant to make free elections a priority over the current economic and diplomatic arrangements, said former U.S. officials and people involved in discussions with the White House.

前美国官员和参与白宫讨论的人士表示，如果特朗普在委内瑞拉的经济政策上得到他想要的，总统可能不愿将自由选举置于当前的经济和外交安排之上。

Still, some in the Trump administration are wary of the current arrangement with Rodriguez. The first senior U.S. official to meet with Rodriguez was Central Intelligence Agency Director John Ratcliffe, who on a Jan. 15 trip to the Venezuelan capital, Caracas, warned regime figures to end support for drug traffickers. A recent U.S. intelligence assessment cast doubt on Rodriguez's willingness to distance herself from China, Iran and Russia, one of Trump's demands, said a U.S. intelligence official.

尽管如此，特朗普政府中的一些人对与罗德里格斯的当前安排持谨慎态度。第一位与罗德里格斯会面的高级美国官员是中央情报局局长约翰·拉特克利夫，他在1月15日访问委内瑞拉首都加拉加斯时，警告政权人物停止支持毒贩。一位美国情报官员表示，最近的一份美国情报评估对罗德里格斯是否愿意与中国、伊朗和俄罗斯保持距离（这是特朗普的要求之一）表示怀疑。

"They're hoping to wait out Trump, that's why we can't allow that," Rep. Carlos Gimenez (R., Fla.) said about Rodriguez's interim government. "As soon as they think they have the upper hand, they'll tell us to go away."

"他们希望拖延特朗普，这就是我们不能允许的原因，"佛罗里达州共和党众议员卡洛斯·吉梅内斯谈到罗德里格斯的临时政府时说，"一旦他们认为自己占了上风，他们就会叫我们走开。"

Some Trump officials have sought to reassure lawmakers, foreign leaders and business executives that the cooperation with Rodriguez is temporary. U.S. Energy Secretary Chris Wright has told American executives there would be elections in 18 to 24 months, a person present said.

一些特朗普官员试图向议员、外国领导人和商界高管保证，与罗德里格斯的合作是暂时的。一位在场人士表示，美国能源部长克里斯·赖特告诉美国高管，将在18到24个月内举行选举。

So far, prominent members of Venezuela's opposition have been reluctant to criticize Trump's strategy, at least publicly.

到目前为止，委内瑞拉反对派的知名成员一直不愿批评特朗普的策略，至少在公开场合是这样。

María Corina Machado, the Nobel Peace Prize-winning opposition leader who is currently exiled in the U.S., privately told Rubio and other U.S. officials on Wednesday that she wanted to return to Venezuela as quickly as possible.

诺贝尔和平奖得主、目前流亡美国的反对派领导人玛丽亚·科里纳·马查多周三私下告诉卢比奥和其他美国官员，她希望尽快返回委内瑞拉。

"Things are happening in Venezuela that were unthinkable just a few days ago," Machado said, referencing the period before the U.S. raid.

"委内瑞拉正在发生几天前还不可思议的事情，"马查多说，她指的是美国突袭之前的时期。

Still, Machado was skeptical about working with Rodriguez. "We are willing to facilitate a genuine transition," she said, "not a Russian-style transition where mafias remain in control."

尽管如此，马查多对与罗德里格斯合作持怀疑态度。"我们愿意促成真正的过渡，"她说，"而不是俄罗斯式的过渡，让黑手党继续掌权。"

On Wednesday, Venevision, one of the country's major television networks, broadcast comments from Machado from Washington—the first time in years the channel had given airtime to the opposition leader. The move drew a rebuke from Diosdado Cabello, the interior minister and de facto leader of some of Venezuela's paramilitary forces.

周三，该国主要电视台之一Venevision播出了马查多在华盛顿的评论——这是该频道多年来首次给予这位反对派领导人播出时间。此举引来了内政部长兼委内瑞拉一些准军事部队实际领导人迪奥斯达多·卡韦略的斥责。

In some settings, Rodriguez says she's working well with Trump and Rubio. In others, she rails against "Washington's orders."

在某些场合，罗德里格斯表示她与特朗普和卢比奥合作良好。在另一些场合，她则抨击"华盛顿的命令"。

All the while, she has been working to consolidate power.

与此同时，她一直在努力巩固权力。

On Wednesday, Venezuela's military and police—including Cabello, widely seen as a figure who could undermine Rodriguez's rule—pledged allegiance to Rodriguez in a ceremony broadcast on state television.

周三，委内瑞拉军队和警察——包括被广泛视为可能削弱罗德里格斯统治的卡韦略——在国家电视台播出的仪式上向罗德里格斯宣誓效忠。

Henrique Capriles, a Maduro adversary who is a lawmaker in Venezuela's National Assembly, said he warned that the opposition couldn't simply rely on the U.S. to ensure there would be free elections.

马杜罗的对手、委内瑞拉国民议会议员恩里克·卡普里莱斯表示，他警告反对派不能仅仅依靠美国来确保举行自由选举。

"The opposition must unite around a common goal," he said, "which is democratic change in Venezuela."

他说："反对派必须围绕一个共同目标团结起来，那就是委内瑞拉的民主变革。"

Ian Lovett is foreign correspondent for The Wall Street Journal covering the war in Ukraine.

伊恩·洛维特是《华尔街日报》的外国记者，负责报道乌克兰战争。

He joined the Journal in 2016 and spent five years covering religion in the United States before the full-scale invasion of Ukraine began. Previously, he worked at the New York Times, where he covered the West Coast and major breaking news across the country.

他于2016年加入《华尔街日报》，在乌克兰全面入侵开始前，他花了五年时间报道美国的宗教事务。此前，他曾在《纽约时报》工作，负责报道美国西海岸和全国各地的重大突发新闻。

Vera Bergengruen is a national security reporter at The Wall Street Journal in Washington, D.C. Before joining the Journal, she was a senior correspondent at Time magazine, where she covered the intersection of national security, tech and politics and reported cover stories from Ukraine, Argentina and El Salvador.

维拉·伯根格鲁恩是《华尔街日报》驻华盛顿特区的国家安全记者。在加入《华尔街日报》之前，她曾是《时代》杂志的高级记者，负责报道国家安全、科技和政治的交叉领域，并从乌克兰、阿根廷和萨尔瓦多发回封面报道。

Previously she worked as a national security and investigative reporter for BuzzFeed News. She began her journalism career at her hometown Miami Herald and its parent company McClatchy, where she did stints covering everything from hurricanes to Congress, the Defense Department and the White House.

此前，她曾担任BuzzFeed News的国家安全和调查记者。她的新闻生涯始于家乡的《迈阿密先驱报》及其母公司McClatchy，在那里她曾报道从飓风到国会、国防部和白宫的一切。

Her work has won the Society of Professional Journalists' Sigma Delta Chi and Dateline Awards and a New York Press Club Award. She was also part of the team that worked on the Pulitzer Prize-winning Panama Papers investigation in 2017. Vera is originally from Uruguay and grew up in Chile, Germany, Mexico and Miami.

她的作品曾获得专业记者协会的Sigma Delta Chi和Dateline奖以及纽约新闻俱乐部奖。她还是2017年普利策奖获奖项目"巴拿马文件"调查团队的一员。维拉最初来自乌拉圭，在智利、德国、墨西哥和迈阿密长大。

TOEIC Vocabulary Study
托业词汇学习

1. administration

/ədˌmɪnɪˈstreɪʃən/

EN: The management of any office, business, or organization; the executive branch of a government.

政府；行政部门；管理

> *"After the raid that captured Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro, the Trump administration called on his vice president, Delcy Rodríguez, to release hundreds of political prisoners—a test of her willingness to break with Maduro's repression."*
>
> **"在抓捕委内瑞拉总统尼古拉斯·马杜罗的突袭行动之后，特朗普政府呼吁其副总统德尔西·罗德里格斯释放数百名政治犯——以此考验她是否愿意打破马杜罗的镇压政策。"**

2. repression

/rɪˈpreʃən/

EN: The act of subduing someone or something by force; the restraint, prevention, or inhibition of a feeling, quality, etc.

镇压；压制；抑制

> *"After the raid that captured Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro, the Trump administration called on his vice president, Delcy Rodríguez, to release hundreds of political prisoners—a test of her willingness to break with Maduro's repression."*
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3. pledged

/pledʒd/

EN: Committed (a person or organization) by a solemn promise.

承诺；保证（pledge的过去式）

> *"Rodriguez on Friday pledged a general amnesty for political prisoners—without making it clear who would be released or when."*
>
> **"罗德里格斯周五承诺对政治犯实行大赦——但没有明确说明谁将获释以及何时获释。"**

4. amnesty

/ˈæmnəsti/

EN: An official pardon for people who have been convicted of political offenses.

大赦；特赦

> *"Rodriguez on Friday pledged a general amnesty for political prisoners—without making it clear who would be released or when."*
>
> **"罗德里格斯周五承诺对政治犯实行大赦——但没有明确说明谁将获释以及何时获释。"**

5. strategy

/ˈstrætədʒi/

EN: A plan of action or policy designed to achieve a major or overall aim.

策略；战略

> *"Her handling of U.S. pressure over political prisoners reflects Rodriguez's broader strategy, said current and former U.S. officials and the Venezuelan opposition."*
>
> **"现任和前任美国官员以及委内瑞拉反对派表示，她处理美国在政治犯问题上的压力，反映了罗德里格斯更广泛的策略。"**

6. concessions

/kənˈseʃənz/

EN: Things granted, especially in response to demands; a compromise.

让步；特许（concession的复数）

> *"The 56-year-old interim leader appears to be betting that time is on her side, offering the U.S. president the kind of economic deals and concessions he prizes to convince him that a managed status quo is better than a destabilizing, uncertain transition."*
>
> **"这位56岁的临时领导人似乎在赌时间站在她这一边，向美国总统提供他所珍视的经济协议和让步，以说服他受控的现状优于破坏稳定、不确定的过渡。"**

7. liability

/ˌlaɪəˈbɪləti/

EN: The state of being responsible for something, especially by law; a person or thing whose presence or behavior is likely to cause embarrassment or put one at a disadvantage.

责任；负债；不利因素

> *"As the 2026 midterms approach, U.S. involvement in Venezuela could become a political liability for Trump, giving Rodriguez and her allies an incentive to run out the clock, people involved in U.S. discussions about Venezuela said."*

"参与美国与委内瑞拉讨论的人士表示，随着2026年中期选举临近，美国介入委内瑞拉可能成为特朗普的政治负担，这给了罗德里格斯及其盟友拖延时间的动机。"

8. interim

/ˈɪntərɪm/

EN: In or for the intervening period; provisional or temporary.

临时的；过渡的

"The 56-year-old interim leader appears to be betting that time is on her side, offering the U.S. president the kind of economic deals and concessions he prizes to convince him that a managed status quo is better than a destabilizing, uncertain transition."

"这位56岁的临时领导人似乎在赌时间站在她这一边，向美国总统提供他所珍视的经济协议和让步，以说服他受控的现状优于破坏稳定、不确定的过渡。"

9. leverage

/ˈliːvərɪdʒ/

EN: The use of something to maximum advantage; power to influence a person or situation.

影响力；杠杆作用

"A White House official said that the U.S. now has control and leverage over Venezuela's interim authorities and that the Venezuelan people would be responsible for making transformational changes to their country."

"一位白宫官员表示，美国现在对委内瑞拉临时当局拥有控制权和影响力，委内瑞拉人民将负责对其国家进行变革。"

10. sanctioned

/ˈsæŋkʃənd/

EN: Imposed a penalty on (a country, organization, or person) for breaking international law or as a means of coercion.

制裁；批准（sanction的过去式）

"In Trump's first term, Rodriguez was sanctioned for her role in helping Maduro "maintain power and solidify his authoritarian rule.""

"在特朗普的第一任期内，罗德里格斯因帮助马杜罗"维持权力并巩固其独裁统治"而受到制裁。"